

Abhinav Bindra: When I was competing for over two decades, my perspective was very narrow. But now that I've exited my investment and I look at things more dispassionately, I see many other areas and facets to sport, which perhaps I didn't pay enough value to or attention to while I was an athlete because my job as an athlete was simply to win.

On the other side, I see sport's larger role. I see the true power of sport towards nation building. We're at a time in our nation's history where we're either consuming or playing sport. At a time like that, we need to look at how platforms like the Aces Awards give us a chance to recognise what the nation's sporting culture looks like.



Viswanathan Anand: The chess ecosystem has steadily progressed and expanded, but at the same time, you have to specify that we are living in a special moment to have this kind of bench with so many talented youngsters, principally in the men's team, but also in the women's team. And challenging for the world title, breaking records in the rating list, the ranking list. This is a special moment. And I think chess is a sport which will be in the sports awards a lot over the next decade at least.

To those who have won, all I want to say is enjoy. This is a national recognition by a great sports institution. It is an acknowledgement by your peers and your fans of what you did.

Anjali Bhagwat: Shooting, as an ecosystem, took intelligent steps forward after Tokyo. The federation brought in local coaches to handle local shooters who weren't comfortable with foreign languages. It was an opportunity for our homegrown coaches to also upgrade their skills by working with foreign coaches. It was solid teamwork that got us to where we did in Paris.

That apart, this generation is very smart and the shooters know what they're doing and how to handle themselves. When I used to shoot, there was apprehension and a lack of confidence around international shooters. We used to go thinking 'Oh, the Chinese Team is there, the USA team is there.' Now the rest of the world thinks India is arriving. The Indian team is here now and has established that dominance for which our shooters have worked very hard.



Aparna Popat: The conversations that we've had over the years sort of come to fruition. To say that girls and women should play sport and discuss what sport does for them beyond the playing field and then see that translate to numbers entering the ecosystem is heartening. It's translating into medals too. We've got such brilliant role models in the female athletes coming through now and that then sets the stage for more girls to participate in sport and then hopefully we widen the scope of medals coming from women. It was the year of the gender-neutral Olympics as well. The fact that the competition field has been evened out and women are emerging as genuine contenders is a powerful change that needs to keep making its way across the country.